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## THE IMPACT OF FEAR OF MISSING OUT (FOMO) ON THE CONSUMER BEHAVIOR OF COLLEGE STUDENTS IN HOLY CROSS COLLEGE

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## CHAPTER 1 THE PROBLEM AND ITS SETTING

### Introduction

Consumer behavior has been transformed by the use of social media and online platforms. Today's consumers are exposed to constant streams of product information, influencer endorsements, and peer activity updates, which shape their attitudes and purchasing decisions. Online marketing strategies and digital social networks not only provide convenience but also create psychological triggers that influence behavior. One such factor is the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO), a phenomenon defined as the anxiety or apprehension that others might be experiencing rewarding experiences while one is absent. This anxiety often drives individuals to remain connected to social media and to engage in trending activities, including immediate consumption of products and services (Neumann, 2020).

FOMO has gained increasing attention in recent years, particularly within the context of consumer behavior and digital marketing. Social media platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook present highly curated content showcasing peers, influencers, and celebrities engaging in lifestyle trends or purchasing popular products. According to Kurniawati and Umam (2024), such exposure heightens the likelihood that young consumers, especially college students, will experience FOMO, motivating them to make purchases in order to remain socially relevant or avoid feeling excluded. The influence of FOMO is particularly significant among college students, a group characterized by high social media engagement and frequent online shopping activity. Students often make consumption choices not solely based on rational evaluation but

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also on emotional responses triggered by social comparison and perceived scarcity of products. Mahena, Sofiah, and Arifiana (2024) found that individuals experiencing high levels of FOMO are more likely to engage in impulsive buying behaviors, prioritizing social inclusion and trend participation over careful decision making.

Consumer behavior, traditionally conceptualized as a rational and systematic process, involves stages such as problem recognition, information search, evaluation of alternatives, purchase, and evaluation after purchase. However, contemporary research suggests that emotional and psychological factors significantly influence this process. Ayyasy et al. (2025) emphasize that in today's digital era, FOMO can disrupt rational evaluation by creating urgency and fear of exclusion, which may lead consumers to make impulsive or unplanned purchases. Marketing strategies that use messages of scarcity or limited availability are particularly effective in leveraging FOMO to influence consumer behavior.

The connection between FOMO and consumer behavior is especially relevant among college students, who belong to Generation Z and are considered digital natives. This group is highly exposed to online social environments where peer influence and social validation shape behavior. Permana et al. (2024) note that social comparison and peer pressure can amplify FOMO, leading students to make hasty purchasing decisions in order to align with perceived social norms or trending behaviors.

Despite the growing recognition of FOMO as a driver of consumer behavior, there is a need to better understand its specific effect on the consumer behavior of college students. While prior studies have explored the relationship between FOMO

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and impulsive buying, fewer studies focus on how FOMO impacts each stage of decision making, from recognizing needs to evaluating purchases, particularly in the context of social media marketing. Investigating this relationship is important not only for understanding modern consumer behavior but also for providing insights that can guide responsible consumption among young consumers and inform digital marketing strategies for businesses.

This study aims to examine the impact of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on the consumer behavior of college students in Holy Cross College. Specifically, it seeks to determine how FOMO influences the evaluation of products, urgency in purchasing, and impulsive buying tendencies. By exploring this relationship, the study contributes to a deeper understanding of psychological and social influences on modern consumer behavior and highlights the implications of digital marketing strategies in shaping the purchasing patterns of college students.

## **Review of Related Literature**

This section provides a comprehensive review of previous studies relevant to the core research problem. Rather than a simple summary, it offers a critical synthesis of the theories, methodologies, and empirical findings contributed by key scholars in the field. By delineating the specific areas where previous research converges or diverges, this review contextualizes the current study within the broader academic conversation. This analysis serves to pinpoint existing knowledge gaps, thereby clarifying the necessity and academic relevance of the present investigation.

The landscape of consumer behavior has shifted dramatically in the digital era, characterized by a transition from rational decision-making to emotionally driven, spontaneous purchasing. E-commerce and social media platforms expose college students to a constant stream of curated lifestyles and peer activities, frequently triggering the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO). FOMO is a pervasive psychological anxiety that others are experiencing rewarding events without one's participation (Neumann, 2020). Modern digital marketing capitalizes on this vulnerability through scarcity tactics and trend-driven campaigns, which disrupt cognitive evaluation and provoke impulsive buying (Yani & Rojuaniah, 2024).

To understand how FOMO dictates these unplanned consumer actions, recent literature frequently applies the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB). Contemporary applications of TPB effectively illustrate how digital phenomena like FOMO manipulate a consumer's attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control to drive immediate purchasing behavior (Mustika et al., 2024). In the context of digital

consumerism, FOMO acts as a disruptive emotional variable that significantly alters these three core components, ultimately overriding rational decision-making and driving impulsive buying among college students.

### ***Attitude Towards Behavior***

Attitude towards a behavior involves an individual's favorable or unfavorable evaluation of executing that specific action. In traditional retail environments, consumer attitudes are largely shaped by a logical assessment of a product's utility and financial cost. However, within highly digitized social spaces, FOMO radically alters this evaluation metric. When students experience the anxiety of missing out, their attitude toward making an impulsive purchase becomes highly favorable because the transaction is viewed primarily as a mechanism for emotional relief and trend participation (Mendes Martins, 2024). The perceived value of the product shifts from its functional use to its capacity to alleviate social distress. Consequently, the emotional gratification of "belonging" overshadows rational cost-benefit analyses, cultivating a positive attitude toward unplanned and sudden purchases (Yani & Rojuaniah, 2024; Setiawan et al., 2025).

### ***Subjective Norms***

Subjective norms refer to the perceived social pressure to perform or refrain from a specific behavior. For college students, who are deeply embedded in digital culture, peer influence and social validation are paramount. Social media platforms establish continuous, visible measurement for peer norms and lifestyle standards. FOMO significantly amplifies the weight of these subjective norms; when a product or

experience goes viral, the fear of social exclusion generates intense pressure to conform (Eduvest Research, 2025). The continuous exposure to influencer endorsements and peer consumption patterns creates a normative expectation that participating in these trends is required for social acceptance (Kurniawati, Rifqi, & Umam, 2025). As a result, students feel a compelling external pressure to acquire trending items, effectively bypassing rational decision-making to satisfy the perceived expectations of their digital social circles (Neumann, 2020).

### ***Perceived Behavioral Control***

Perceived behavioral control pertains to an individual's perception of the ease or difficulty of performing a behavior, which is linked to their cognitive self-regulation. In the context of digital consumerism, this control is actively undermined by both technological infrastructure and psychological distress. E-commerce platforms utilize frictionless designs—such as one-click purchasing and integrated digital wallets—that minimize the effort required to buy an item (Mustika et al., 2024). Simultaneously, the heightened anxiety and emotional urgency induced by FOMO deplete a student's self-control and cognitive regulation (Elhai et al., 2016). When the intense psychological desire to alleviate FOMO intersects with the extreme ease of online shopping, a student's perceived behavioral control is severely compromised. This reduction in the ability to resist impulsive urges makes them highly susceptible to converting sudden, digitally triggered desires into finalized purchases (Mendes Martins, 2024).

## **Theoretical Framework**

This study is anchored in the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), a highly regarded psychological model used to understand and predict human behavior based on a person's underlying intentions. Even as shopping shifts heavily into the digital space, modern researchers continue to rely on the TPB because it is incredibly effective at explaining complex consumer decisions (Mustika, Ciptagustia, & Nurnida, 2024). According to this framework, an individual's choice to perform a specific action is shaped by three main psychological factors: attitude, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control (Eduvest Research, 2025). In practical terms, when someone genuinely likes the idea of buying a product, feels active social pressure from their peers to do it, and believes they have the money or means to make it happen, their motivation turns into a solid intention. This strong intention serves as the final mental push that turns a simple desire into a real, physical checkout.

For this specific study, the TPB provides the perfect lens to understand exactly why the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) causes college students to make unplanned purchases. FOMO is fundamentally an anxious reaction to the thought of being left out of rewarding social experiences or viral trends (Neumann, 2020). When viewed through the TPB framework, FOMO acts as a powerful emotional trigger that completely rewires a student's normal buying intentions. It interrupts their usual rational thinking by injecting a sudden sense of urgency and emotional vulnerability into the shopping experience. Instead of carefully weighing their finances, students caught in a FOMO cycle often prioritize social belonging and immediate anxiety relief

over practical budgeting (Ayyasy, Belinda, & Dirgantara, 2025).

To systematically measure this phenomenon, the study directly applies the three core variables of the TPB to see exactly how heavily FOMO manipulates student purchasing habits. These variables will be used in the study as follows:

Attitude (ATT) will serve as the primary measure of how a student internally justifies an unplanned purchase. In the context of this study, rather than simply asking if they like a product, this variable will be used to explore if FOMO warps their financial logic. For instance, the survey will measure whether the anxiety of missing out makes them view a spontaneous, trend-based purchase as a necessary act of social survival or emotional relief, rather than a waste of their monthly allowance. By measuring attitude, the researchers can determine if the students genuinely value the items they buy, or if their positive feelings toward the purchase are simply a trauma response to digital anxiety (Mendes Martins, 2024).

Subjective Norms (SJN) will be utilized to quantify the external social pressures driving their consumer behavior. This variable is crucial for understanding the environmental triggers of FOMO. The study will use this construct to assess how heavily students are influenced by what their classmates, friends, and favorite online influencers are buying. By measuring this, the researchers can determine if the fear of social exclusion is strong enough to force students to conform to the purchasing habits of their digital circles, simply to ensure they have shared experiences to talk about and remain socially relevant on campus (Kurniawati, Rifqi, & Umam, 2025).

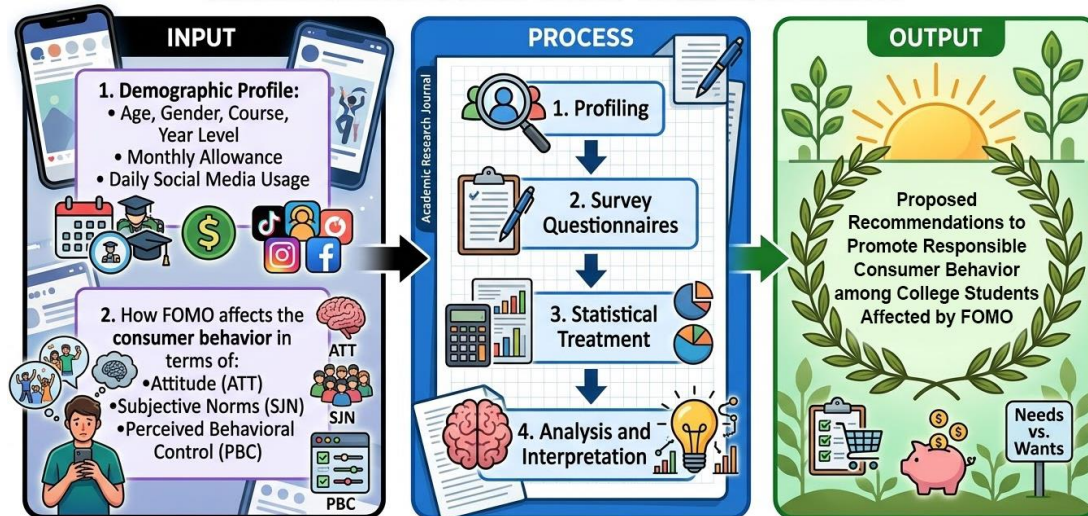
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Perceived Behavioral Control (PBC) will act as the test of the students' financial self-regulation. In a traditional psychological setting, this measures a person's ability to easily complete a task. In this study, however, it will be used to measure their inability to resist a purchase when FOMO strikes. This variable will specifically gauge how easily their willpower breaks down when faced with limited-time offers, flash sales, or viral products on platforms like TikTok and Instagram. It will reveal whether the emotional urgency generated by FOMO completely overrides their cognitive self-discipline, leading directly to immediate and impulsive digital consumption (Setiawan, Susanti, & Rahmawati, 2025).

## Conceptual Framework

**Figure 1**  
*Research Paradigm*



This study utilizes the Input-Process-Output (IPO) model to serve as the conceptual framework for the research. Rather than simply listing variables, this framework visually and logically maps out the entire journey of the study, showing exactly how raw data collected from the students will be transformed into practical, real-world solutions. By following this model, the researchers can track the flow of information from the initial data gathering all the way to the final recommendations.

The input phase represents the foundational data that the researchers need to collect from the respondents to answer the study's main objectives. As illustrated in the paradigm, this phase is divided into two vital components. The first component is the demographic profile of the students, which captures essential background details including their age, gender, specific course and year level, estimated monthly

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allowance, and daily social media usage. Gathering this information is necessary to establish a clear picture of the students' financial standing and digital habits. The second and core component of the input focuses on the primary problem: measuring exactly how the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) affects consumer behavior. To capture this complex psychological experience, the researchers will gather data on three specific behavioral areas: the students' Attitude (ATT) toward making purchases, the Subjective Norms (SJN) representing the social pressure they feel from peers, and their Perceived Behavioral Control (PBC), which measures their ability to regulate their spending.

The process phase acts as the methodological part of the research, outlining the exact chronological steps the researchers will take to turn the raw input into meaningful insights. This phase follows a strict four-step procedure. It begins with profiling, where the researchers will carefully identify and select the appropriate student respondents from the campus. Once the right participants are selected, the second step involves the administration of structured survey questionnaires to gather their direct, firsthand experiences regarding FOMO and shopping. After all the responses are securely collected, the third step subjects the raw data to statistical treatment, using specific mathematical tools to quantify the trends. Finally, the fourth step involves a thorough analysis and interpretation of the calculated results, allowing the researchers to uncover the true narrative behind the numbers and draw evidence-based conclusions.

The output phase represents the goal of the entire research. Drawing directly from the insights uncovered during the analysis and interpretation phase, the study aims to synthesize its findings into a concrete, actionable product. The direct output of this

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research will be a set of proposed recommendations to promote responsible consumer behavior among college students affected by FOMO. These guidelines are designed to help young adults navigate the pressures of social media, resist the urge of impulsive digital shopping, and develop healthier financial habits.

## **Statement of the Problem**

This study aims to determine the impact of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on the consumer behavior of college students in Holy Cross College. It particularly explores how FOMO serves as a mediator when these psychological needs are unmet, leading to impulsive and unplanned purchasing decisions.

Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. How may the demographic of the respondents be described in terms of;
  - 1.1. Age;
  - 1.2. Gender;
  - 1.3. Course and Year Level;
  - 1.4. Estimated Monthly Allowance; and
  - 1.5. Daily social media usage and primary platforms used?
2. How may the consumer behavior of Holy Cross College students be described in terms of:
  - 2.1. Attitude (ATT);
  - 2.2. Subjective norms (SJN); and
  - 2.3. Perceived behavioral control (PBC);

3. What recommendations can be suggested to promote responsible consumer behavior among college students affected by FOMO?

## **Scope and Delimitations of the Study**

This study primarily focuses on examining the impact of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on the consumer behavior of college students in Holy Cross College. The study is confined to college students currently enrolled at Holy Cross College in Rizal, Santa Rosa, Nueva Ecija, who are active users of social media platforms.

Specifically, it investigates how the experience of FOMO in digital environments influences impulsive and unplanned purchasing behaviors by altering the students' attitude towards trending products, subjective norms (peer and social media influence), and perceived behavioral control. Furthermore, the scope includes an assessment of the respondents' demographic profiles, specifically their age, gender, course, year level, monthly allowance, and daily social media usage and primary platforms to establish the context of their digital and financial decision-making.

The research is expressly delimited to the college student demographic within the specified institution; it does not cover other age groups, working professionals, or students from other academic institutions or regions. Due to the use of cluster sampling, data collection is delimited to students enrolled within specific, randomly selected academic departments, rather than surveying the entire college population. Methodologically, the study is confined to a quantitative approach utilizing a structured survey questionnaire to gather data, meaning the findings will rely exclusively on the self-reported responses of the participants during the designated study period.

Moreover, the investigation isolates the relationship between digital FOMO, the components of the Theory of Planned Behavior, and impulsive consumer behavior. It intentionally excludes other potential external variables that might influence buying behavior, such as familial financial background, broader economic inflation, offline peer pressure, or the internal digital marketing algorithms of specific corporate brands. While the study provides valuable insights into the local student population, the results are highly contextualized to the selected sample and cannot be broadly generalized to all young adult consumers.

## **Significance of the Study**

This study, “the impact of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on the consumer behavior of college students in Holy Cross College,” holds significant value in both academic understanding and practical application. By utilizing the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) to know the psychological mechanisms of digital consumerism, the findings of this research will be highly beneficial to the following sectors:

For the primary subjects of this study, this research provides critical insight into how the experience of FOMO psychologically manipulates **College Students’** purchasing decisions, specifically regarding impulsive and unplanned transactions. By understanding how digital platforms artificially inflate the social pressure to conform (subjective norms) and disrupt their financial self-regulation (perceived behavioral control), students can become more self-aware of their spending triggers. This awareness equips them with the cognitive tools necessary to develop better financial discipline and make more rational, need-based consumption choices.

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The study emphasizes the importance of understanding the behavioral and psychological factors that shape modern youth consumerism. **Educators and Academic Institutions** will benefit from these findings by gaining a clearer picture of the digital pressures their students face. This empirical data can be utilized to design and implement highly targeted campus programs, such as financial literacy seminars or digital wellness campaigns, that actively teach students how to navigate peer pressure and social media marketing.

For **Businesses and Digital Marketers**, this study highlights the role of psychological motivations in driving Generation Z's consumption. It provides businesses and digital marketers with valuable, data-driven insights into how FOMO affects consumer attitudes and subjective norms. While these insights explain how sudden purchases are triggered, they also serve as a guide for the development of more ethical, transparent marketing strategies that build long-term brand loyalty rather than relying on exploitative scarcity tactics or digital anxiety.

This research contributes a modernized perspective to the **Future Researchers** on consumer behavior and psychology by applying the Theory of Planned Behavior to the contemporary issue of digital FOMO. It provides foundational empirical data on the relationship between digital anxiety and decision-making among college students. Consequently, it will serve as a robust reference point for future academicians and researchers who wish to further explore the intersections of e-commerce, digital peer influence, and the psychological vulnerabilities of young adult consumers.

## **Definition of Terms**

The terms explained below have been conceptually defined. Some are defined operational so that the researchers can better understand how these terms relate to the current study.

**Attitude Towards Behavior.** Refers to an individual's favorable or unfavorable evaluation of executing a specific action. In this study, it highlights how FOMO shifts a student's attitude from a logical evaluation of a product's utility to viewing an impulsive purchase favorably as a means of achieving emotional gratification and trend participation. (sciencedirect.com)

**Cluster Sampling.** Is a probability sampling technique wherein the target population is divided into naturally occurring groups (clusters), and a random selection of these groups is surveyed entirely. In this research, it refers to the random selection of specific academic departments at Holy Cross College to gather a statistically representative sample. (scribbr.com)

**Consumer Behavior.** Refers to the actions, attitudes, and decision-making processes of individuals when selecting, purchasing, and evaluating products or services. In this study, it specifically refers to how Generation Z college students make purchasing decisions influenced by digital marketing and peer pressure. (ama.org)

**Consumer Decision-Making.** Is the cognitive and behavioral process by which individuals evaluate, select, and purchase products or services. In this study, it examines how the traditional, rational decision-making process of college students is disrupted and accelerated by digital social pressures. (sciencedirect.com)

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**Digital Marketing.** Is a series of marketing activities that utilize digital technologies, platforms, and social media networks to promote products or services. In this context, it refers to the strategies that trigger consumer awareness and emotional purchasing intentions among college students. (ama.org)

**E-commerce Platforms.** Are digital marketplaces and applications (e.g., Shopee, TikTok Shop) that facilitate the buying and selling of goods over the internet. These platforms provide the technological infrastructure that enables the sudden, frictionless purchasing behaviors observed in this study. (sciencedirect.com)

**Fear of Missing Out (FOMO).** Is a pervasive psychological anxiety that others might be experiencing rewarding events, possessing desirable items, or participating in valuable trends without one's participation. This anxiety drives a continuous desire to stay connected to social media and serves as the primary psychological trigger investigated in this study. (psychologytoday.com)

**Financial Self-Regulation.** Is an individual's ability to monitor, control, and govern their own financial spending based on personal budgets and rational needs. In this study, it is a key component of Perceived Behavioral Control that is often compromised when students experience high levels of FOMO. (apa.org)

**Frictionless Purchasing.** Refers to the seamless, fast, and highly accessible methods of buying items online, heavily utilizing features like one-click checkouts and integrated digital wallets. This technological ease lowers a student's perceived behavioral control, making it harder to resist sudden urges. (forbes.com)

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**Generation Z (Gen Z).** Refers to individuals born approximately between 1997 and 2012. In this research, this demographic represents the college student respondents who are considered "digital natives," highly engaged with social media, and uniquely susceptible to online social influences. (pewresearch.org)

**Hedonic Shopping.** Defines shopping behaviors motivated by pleasure, enjoyment, fantasy, or emotional satisfaction rather than strict functional needs. In this study, it refers to students buying trending products purely for the emotional excitement and social thrill of participating in a digital trend. (sciencedirect.com)

**Impulsive Buying.** Is a sudden, emotionally driven, and unplanned purchase made without prior cognitive deliberation or financial planning. In the context of this study, it is the primary behavioral outcome triggered by the combination of digital FOMO and social media exposure. (apa.org)

**Online Shopping Anxiety.** Refers to feelings of psychological distress experienced in digital purchasing environments. While traditionally linked to trust issues, in this study, it relates to the emotional urgency and anxiety of missing out on a limited-time online product. (sciencedirect.com)

**Peer Influence.** Refers to the direct or indirect impact that friends, social media influencers, and online communities have on an individual's opinions and behaviors. This study evaluates how peer influence establishes the Subjective Norms that drive students to purchase specific items. (apa.org)

**Perceived Behavioral Control.** Is an individual's belief in their capability, resources, and self-regulation to perform or resist a behavior. Here, it refers to a student's

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diminishing cognitive self-control and ability to resist sudden purchases when faced with FOMO and highly accessible digital payment methods. (sciencedirect.com)

**Purchase Decision.** Is the final stage in the consumer decision-making process where the individual executes the transaction. In this study, it focuses on the sudden, uncalculated execution of buying trending products online as a result of psychological triggers. (sciencedirect.com)

**Scarcity Marketing.** Is a digital marketing tactic that artificially creates a sense of limited availability or limited time for a product (e.g., "Flash Sales"). This study explores how scarcity marketing heavily exploits FOMO to pressure students into impulsive purchases. (psychologytoday.com)

**Social Comparison.** Is the psychological tendency of individuals to evaluate their own social and personal worth by comparing their experiences and possessions with those of others online. This tendency is a core driver of FOMO among the student respondents. (psychologytoday.com)

**Subjective Norms.** Refers to the perceived social pressure from peers, influencers, and digital society to perform or refrain from a specific behavior. In this study, it represents the intense pressure students feel to purchase trending online items in order to achieve social validation and avoid digital exclusion. (sciencedirect.com)

**Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB).** Is the primary psychological and theoretical framework utilized in this study to understand and predict consumer actions. (sciencedirect.com)

## CHAPTER 2

### RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

#### **Research Design**

This study employs a quantitative and descriptive research design using a survey method to investigate the impact of the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on the consumer behavior of college students at Holy Cross College in Santa Rosa, Nueva Ecija. This design is chosen because it allows for the collection of quantifiable data that can be statistically analyzed to identify patterns, trends, and relationships among variables such as social media exposure and impulsive buying tendencies. According to Creswell (2016), quantitative research involves testing theories by examining the relationship among variables which can be measured and analyzed using statistical procedures. This approach is essential for providing a structured and objective analysis of behavioral data, ensuring that the findings regarding the relationship between psychological anxiety and purchasing actions are reliable.

Descriptive research is suitable for capturing data in natural social environments without experimental manipulation, providing a clear perspective of how digital platforms shape the attitudes and decisions of Generation Z students. This approach effectively captures real world practices such as making consumption choices based on social comparison and perceived scarcity as they exist during the study period. By utilizing this design, the study can describe the current state of consumer behavior among students who are frequently exposed to curated content and influencer activity on platforms like TikTok and Instagram. The survey instrument will collect three

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primary categories of data: the demographic profiles of the respondents including age, sex, course, and daily social media usage; the extent of FOMO experienced by the students as a mediating factor; and the specific ways this anxiety influences their decision-making process in terms of impulsive and unplanned purchasing tendencies. The study also examines how students may prioritize social inclusion and trend participation over careful, systematic evaluation when making choices.

By applying this quantitative and descriptive approach, the study aims to generate objective insights that can guide students in developing more informed consumption habits and assist businesses in understanding the psychological triggers of young consumers. This design supports the investigation into whether a significant relationship exists between FOMO and the resulting consumer behavior of college students, providing a comprehensive view of how social and digital pressures impact the purchasing patterns of the student population.

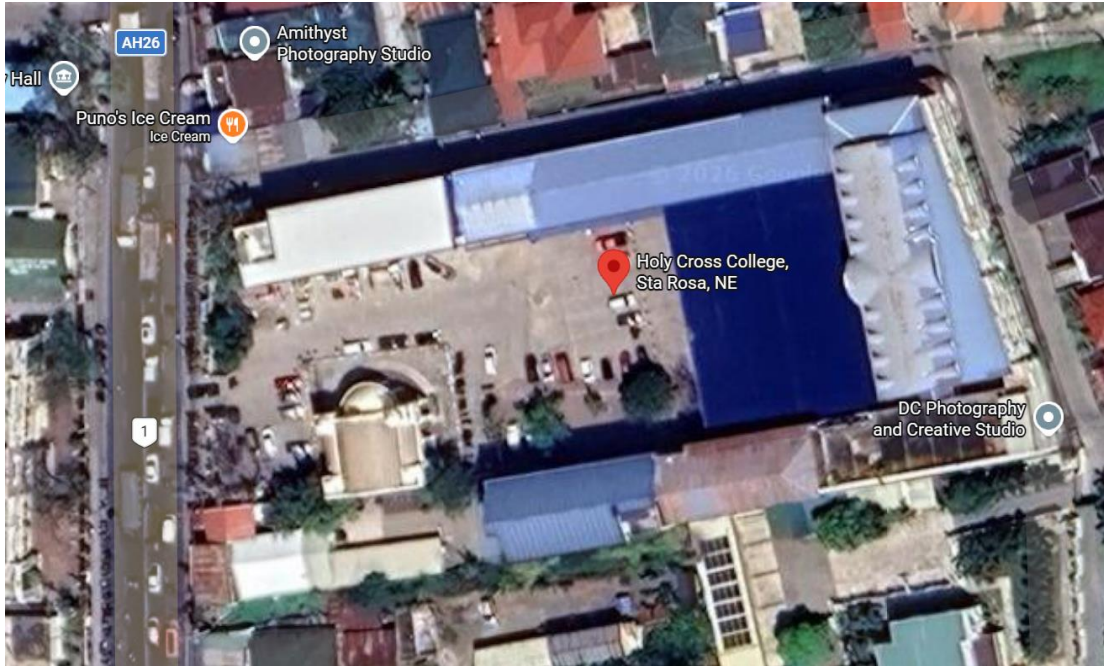
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## Research Locale

**Figure 2**

*Location Map of Holy Cross College, Sta. Rosa, N.E. Inc*



The locale of this study is situated at Holy Cross College in Brgy. Rizal, Santa Rosa, Nueva Ecija, an academic institution known for its excellence in teaching and instilling core values to its faculties, staff, and students. Its location near residential areas and local business centers creates a stable environment where students frequently interact with digital platforms and social media trends. Many students actively use social networking sites such as Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook, which generate continuous digital interactions that influence their consumer behavior and lifestyle choices. Studies indicate that constant exposure to social media environments can increase the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) among young individuals, encouraging them to stay updated with trends and participate in online activities and purchases to avoid

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feeling excluded. Research shows that FOMO is strongly associated with impulsive purchasing behavior, particularly among young consumers who frequently engage with social networking platforms.

This specific setting at Holy Cross College allows researchers to gather reliable data from respondents regarding their psychological motivations and purchasing actions. The high level of student interaction within the municipality of Santa Rosa, Nueva Ecija provides a relevant environment for examining how FOMO affects the everyday choices of young individuals. Academic institutions are considered appropriate environments for studying social comparison and peer influence because students regularly interact with peers and are exposed to shared social expectations. These factors can influence decision making processes, especially in contexts related to identity formation, belongingness, and lifestyle choices. Studies on Generation Z consumers suggest that social comparison and peer validation often play significant roles in shaping purchasing decisions and consumption patterns within educational communities.

The campus environment also demonstrates frequent consumer behaviors through the sharing of trends, recommendations, and online reviews about various products and services. Social media discussions, influencer content, and peer recommendations can create psychological triggers that encourage unplanned or impulsive purchases among students. Research indicates that FOMO and social media engagement can significantly influence impulse buying tendencies because individuals may feel pressure to keep up with trends or participate in popular online experiences.

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The accessibility of the area and the active digital engagement of students make the campus an appropriate setting for observing how marketing strategies, social influence, and psychological factors interact in shaping consumer behavior. Social media platforms create digital social spaces where peer interactions, algorithm-driven recommendations, and trend circulation rapidly affect consumer attitudes and purchasing decisions. As a result, studying students within this environment provides valuable insights into how FOMO contributes to impulsive buying and consumer decision-making among young individuals.

## **Sample and Sampling Procedure**

The respondents of this study are college students currently enrolled at Holy Cross College in Santa Rosa, Nueva Ecija. To ensure a representative and statistically sound selection of participants, this study will utilize cluster sampling. Cluster sampling can be defined as a method where the population is divided into naturally occurring groups, or clusters, and a random sample of these clusters is selected for study (Alex, 2024). It can also be combined with other sampling techniques in multistage sampling designs. This cost-effective approach is efficient, especially for large, geographically dispersed populations. For instance, a national health survey assessing diabetes prevalence might divide the country into districts (clusters), randomly select several districts, and then survey all or a random sample of individuals within those districts. This method simplifies logistics and reduces costs while maintaining a representative sample, making it ideal for applications in national

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surveys, educational research, public health assessments, market research, and environmental studies.

In the context of this study, the primary clusters will be specifically defined by the students' course, year level, and section within Holy Cross College. Rather than broadly selecting entire academic departments, the researchers will first compile a complete and detailed list of all active classes, properly categorized by their specific degree programs, respective year levels, and designated sections. Once a specific section is chosen as a cluster, the researchers will approach that class and administer the survey to the students within it, ensuring a highly organized and representative distribution of respondents across different academic levels. Once the specific departmental clusters are chosen, the researchers will distribute the survey questionnaires to the students enrolled within those selected departments. However, because the phenomenon of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) heavily relies on digital exposure and online peer interaction, the target respondents must have direct experience with the digital behavior under investigation. Therefore, a screening question will be placed at the beginning of the survey to ensure that the respondents from the selected clusters are active users of social media platforms (e.g., Facebook, TikTok, Instagram). Only the data from respondents who confirm active daily social media usage will be included in the final statistical analysis.

This cluster sampling approach allows the researchers to efficiently gather a large, representative sample from a localized campus population while minimizing selection bias. By surveying entire selected academic clusters, the study ensures that

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the findings regarding digital consumer behavior and the Theory of Planned Behavior accurately reflect a cross-section of the broader student body, making the data highly reliable and aligned with the research objectives.

## **Data Gathering Procedure**

To ensure a systematic and ethical collection of data, the researchers will strictly follow a structured procedure in gathering the necessary information for this study. Upon the finalization and validation of the survey instrument, the researchers will send a formal letter of request to the college administration and the respective department heads of Holy Cross College. This letter will outline the objectives of the study and seek official approval to conduct the survey among the student body within the campus premises.

Before any testing occurs, the drafted survey questionnaire will be subjected to rigorous content and face validation. The researchers will present the instrument to a qualified academic or industry expert holding at least a Master's degree in Business Administration, Marketing, Psychology, or a closely related field. The expert validator will evaluate the questionnaire to ensure that the Likert scale statements are relevant, clear, unbiased, and perfectly aligned with the research variables (FOMO and consumer behavior). All feedback, corrections, and recommendations provided by the expert will be carefully integrated into the revised draft of the instrument.

Before the main data collection, a pilot test will be conducted to establish the reliability and clarity of the questionnaire. The survey will be administered to a small sample of college students (approximately 15 to 30 individuals) who are active social

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media users but will not be included in the final, official sample. This trial run allows the researchers to identify any confusing instructions, vague questions, or formatting errors. Feedback from the pilot test will be evaluated, and necessary revisions will be applied to the Likert scale statements to ensure the instrument accurately measures the impact of FOMO on consumer behavior before the mass distribution.

Once official approval is granted, the researchers will execute the cluster sampling procedure. A complete list of the academic departments will be obtained, and a specific number of departments will be selected randomly. The researchers will then visit the classrooms or designated common areas of these selected departments to approach the potential respondents. Before handing out the survey, the researchers will briefly introduce themselves, explain the purpose and significance of the study, and present the screening question to ensure that only active social media users participate in the survey.

Qualified students who agree to participate will be provided with the informed consent form alongside the structured questionnaire. The researchers will explicitly remind the respondents that their participation is entirely voluntary and that all their answers will be kept strictly confidential. The respondents will be given sufficient time to read the instructions and answer the Likert scale questions by themselves. The survey will be administered in a controlled campus environment to minimize outside interruptions and allow the students to answer thoughtfully.

Immediately after the respondents finish answering, the researchers will collect the questionnaires and conduct a preliminary check to ensure that there are no missing

or unanswered items. Once all the necessary data from the selected clusters are completely retrieved, the researchers will compile, tally, and logically code the responses into a secure database. The consolidated data will then be subjected to the appropriate statistical treatment and analysis to answer the study's specific statement of the problem. All physical and digital records will be stored securely in compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012, ensuring that the information is used exclusively for this academic research.

## **Data Gathering Instrument**

This study will utilize a structured, self-administered survey questionnaire as the primary tool for data collection. The instrument is specifically designed to quantitatively describe the level of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) and its perceived impact on the consumer behavior of college students in Holy Cross College. To ensure the relevance and accuracy of the data, the questionnaire is constructed based on the constructs of the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) and is divided into comprehensive sections.

The first section is designed to gather the personal and digital background of the respondents. It includes profiling questions regarding the student's age, gender, course, year level, estimated monthly allowance, and their daily social media usage (including their primary platforms). This section directly answers the first statement of the problem and establishes the contextual baseline for the respondents' digital and financial behavior.

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The second section assesses the independent variable of the study. It contains a series of statements aimed at measuring the frequency and intensity of the psychological anxiety students experience when they feel excluded from trending digital experiences or peer purchases.

## **Data Analysis Technique**

The data gathered from the structured survey questionnaires will be tallied, tabulated, and subjected to rigorous statistical treatment using appropriate statistical software (e.g., MS Excel or SPSS). To ensure accurate interpretation and to answer the specific statements of the problem, the following statistical tools will be utilized:

1. Frequency Count and Percentage will be used to describe the demographic profile of the respondents (Part I of the questionnaire), specifically their age, gender, course, year level, estimated monthly allowance, and daily social media usage.

Formula:

$$P = (f / N) \times 100$$

Where:

*P = Percentage*

*f = Frequency (number of responses in a specific category)*

*N = Total number of respondents*

*100 as the constant multiplier*

2. Weighted Mean will be utilized to quantify and determine the respondents' level of Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) and the extent of its influence on their consumer

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decision-making based on the Theory of Planned Behavior constructs (Parts II and III of the questionnaire).

Formula:

$$WM = (\sum fx) / N$$

Where:

$WM$  = *Weighted Mean*

$f$  = *Frequency of responses for each scale*

$x$  = *Weight of the response (degree of response from 1 to 4)*

$N$  = *Total number of respondents*

To interpret the computed weighted mean of the respondents' answers, the following 4-point Likert scale configuration will be used:

**Table 1**  
*Likert Scale*

| Degree of Response | Range       | Verbal Description | Verbal Interpretation        |
|--------------------|-------------|--------------------|------------------------------|
| 4                  | 3.25 – 4.00 | Strongly Agree     | Highly Evident / High Impact |
| 3                  | 2.50 – 3.24 | Agree              | Evident / Moderate Impact    |
| 2                  | 1.75 – 2.49 | Disagree           | Less Evident / Low Impact    |
| 1                  | 1.00 – 1.74 | Strongly Disagree  | Not Evident/No Impact        |

## **Ethical Consideration**

This research will be conducted with a firm commitment to universally accepted ethical standards in academic research. The dignity, rights, and overall well-being of all student participants will remain the primary concern of the researchers throughout

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the entire data-gathering procedure.

Prior to the administration of the survey, the researchers will secure the informed consent of the respondents. The participants will be provided with full disclosure regarding the purpose, objectives, and scope of the study. It will be explicitly stated that their participation is entirely voluntary and that they reserve the right to decline or withdraw from the study at any time without facing any negative academic or personal consequences.

Confidentiality and anonymity protocols will be upheld throughout the research process. In strict compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012 (Republic Act No. 10173), no personally identifiable information (such as names or specific student numbers) will be collected. All gathered responses will be secured with the highest level of protection, stored safely, and made accessible only to the primary research team. The respondents will be assured that their data will be utilized exclusively for academic and research purposes.

The survey instrument will be carefully constructed and validated to exclude potentially intrusive or distressing questions, ensuring the respondents do not feel uncomfortable or upset while participating. Furthermore, participants will be granted the liberty to skip any question they prefer not to answer without any pressure from the researchers.

Finally, the researchers commit to maintaining the utmost academic integrity. The outcomes of the study will be reported truthfully, objectively, and impartially—free from any invention, alteration, or data distortion. Appropriate intellectual property

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credit and accurate citations will be consistently applied to all references and resources  
utilized in the formulation of this manuscript.

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